

MODULE 5 - WIRE UP

Wedge Pattern - Five Case Studies

Real operating systems that started narrow and expanded.

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Wedge Pattern - Five Case Studies

The wedge pattern is simple: start narrow, ship the narrow thing well, expand outward only when the narrow thing is solid. Five sanitized case studies below show the pattern in real operating systems. Names and specifics are genericized; the structure is exact.

1. Sample SaaS for service-business templates

The wedge

A horizontal operations platform for service businesses started as a single trade vertical: roofing. Not "we make ops platforms for any service" - just "we run roofing operations end-to-end."

How it expanded

The roofing wedge proved out the patterns: estimate, schedule, dispatch, photo markup, deposit, invoice, follow-up. Once that loop was tight, the same templates ported to siding, gutters, and exteriors-as-a-package. Each new vertical was a fork of the working roofing template, not a re-design.

Lesson

Pick the vertical you understand. Build the entire loop. Resist the urge to abstract before the loop is shipped. The horizontal product is the by-product of the vertical that worked.

2. Sample sports SaaS

The wedge

A platform serving athletes, parents, coaches, and orgs started as a single feature: a free, no-login game scoreboard. Phones in the bleachers, three taps to start a game, a shareable link that strangers could open.

How it expanded

The scoreboard pulled in parents who saved their game history. Saved history pulled in coaches who wanted team-wide stats. Coaches pulled in orgs who wanted the team tools. Each wedge expanded organically - the next surface was driven by users asking for it, not by a roadmap that started from the top.

Lesson

The first wedge has to be free or near-free, immediate, and shareable. Friction kills wedges. The viral loop pulls the next user surface in for you.

3. Sample contracting business

The wedge

A standalone exterior contracting business started as one trade in one county. Not a regional player; not a multi-trade outfit. One trade, one zip code, one phone number.

How it expanded

Inside the wedge, the operations system got tight - estimating, scheduling, follow-up, photo markup, invoicing. Once the loop produced consistent margin, the business added an adjacent trade and an adjacent county on the same operating system. The system was the moat; the trade and the territory were the variables.

Lesson

The wedge does not have to be a software product. A real operating business is the best showcase customer for the patterns the software embodies. "We use it ourselves" is the strongest sales asset there is.

4. Sample done-for-you build for a single client

The wedge

The first custom build for a contractor was scoped narrowly: replace the patchwork of point tools with a single ops surface for one specific business. Not a template; not a product; one client, one build, one deliverable.

How it expanded

After the build shipped, the patterns became the Custom Build Playbook - the operational template for every future custom build. The playbook formalized the phases, the cadence, the verification discipline, the 4-Place Rule. The template is the asset; the original client is the worked example.

Lesson

First custom builds are expensive on purpose. The price covers learning the pattern well enough to template it. By the third or fourth build, the playbook does most of the work and margin lifts.

5. Sample personal fitness brain

The wedge

A personal fitness brain started as a single weekly workflow: log every workout, log every meal, write a one-paragraph reflection on the week. Three files, appended-to weekly. No app, no UI.

How it expanded

After three months of logs, an agent could produce a weekly review automatically - trends, plateaus, deltas from the prior month. A few months later, the same brain was generating week-ahead programming. The wedge was "log everything in plain markdown"; the agent became the value layer on top of consistent logging.

Lesson

You do not need an app to start. Markdown files appended consistently are enough. Agents add value on top of clean inputs. Garbage in, garbage out is more true with agents than with any prior tool.

Cross-cutting patterns

- Every wedge had a real input and a real output. Nothing started from "figure it out."
- Every wedge was narrow enough that the operator could review every output by hand for the first month.
- Every wedge generated logs from day one. The logs became the asset that justified the next expansion.
- Every expansion was driven by users or buyers asking for it - not by a top-down roadmap.
- The brain (the markdown logs and decision history) was the substrate. The agents were the muscles. The wedge was the first muscle.